



MEDIA RELEASE:

The DFSA implements major updates to Crypto Token Regulatory Framework, enhancing market integrity and supporting innovation in DIFC

Dubai, United Arab Emirates, 12 January 2026: The Dubai Financial Services Authority (DFSA), the independent banking, financial services, and markets regulator of the Dubai International Financial Centre (DIFC), has today brought into force its updated regulatory framework for Crypto Tokens in DIFC. The enhanced rules strengthen the DFSA's regime, provide greater clarity for market participants, and support the development of a safe, transparent, and well-regulated digital assets environment.

The introduction of the updated framework follows the DFSA's consultation process in October 2025 and reflects the evolution of its approach since the launch of the Crypto Token regime in 2022. Over the past three years, the DFSA has actively monitored market developments and engaged closely with industry stakeholders and regulatory counterparts to ensure its rules remain robust, globally aligned, and supportive of innovation in DIFC.

A key change under the updated regime is the shift from a DFSA-led suitability assessment to a firm-led assessment. Firms providing financial services involving Crypto Tokens are now directly responsible for determining – on a reasoned and documented basis – whether each Crypto Token they engage with meets the DFSA's suitability criteria. As a result, the DFSA will no longer publish a list of Recognised Crypto Tokens.

This reform is accompanied by enhanced safeguards for investors, refined conduct and operational requirements, and proportionate reporting obligations that better reflect the current state of the global digital assets market.

Charlotte Robins, Managing Director, Policy & Legal of the DFSA, said: *"The DFSA's enhancements to the Crypto Token regime reflect our progressive stance on innovation and proactive response to market developments and feedback. These updated rules provide firms with greater clarity and flexibility, and ensure that our regulatory crypto token regime remains aligned with international best practice. As digital assets continue to evolve, our objective remains clear – to maintain a transparent, and predictable regulatory framework that safeguards market integrity and enables sustainable and responsible market development in DIFC."*

For firms operating or seeking to operate in DIFC, the updated framework provides a clearer and more structured pathway for activities involving Crypto Tokens, including trading, fund and asset management, custody, advisory, and related financial services.



DFSA Digital Assets Webinar

To support market understanding of the updated framework and to provide a broader perspective on how the DFSA and DIFC support innovation in digital assets, the DFSA will host a webinar on 27 January 2026.

The session will provide an overview of the DFSA's regulatory approach to Crypto Tokens, the evolution of the regime, and how the DIFC's ecosystem supports responsible innovation in this space. It will be relevant for existing and prospective market participants seeking to better understand the regulatory environment, the DIFC ecosystem, and the opportunities available for firms considering establishing or expanding digital asset activities in the DIFC rules. To attend the webinar, register your interest [here](#).

The new rules come into force today, 12 January 2026.

For full details on the updated rules on the regulation of Crypto Tokens, please refer to:

- [DFSA website](#)
- [DFSA's notice of amendments to legislation](#)
- [DFSA's Policy Statement on Fiat Crypto Tokens](#)
- [DFSA's Supervisory Guidelines on assessing the suitability of Crypto Tokens](#)

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Editor's notes:

The Dubai Financial Services Authority (DFSA) is the independent regulator of financial services conducted in and from the Dubai International Financial Centre (DIFC), a purpose-built financial free zone in Dubai, UAE. The DFSA regulates and supervises financial services firms and markets in DIFC. These include asset managers, banks, custody and trust services, commodities futures traders, fund managers, insurers and reinsurers, traders of securities and fintech firms. We supervise exchanges and trading platforms for both conduct and prudential purposes, overseeing an international securities exchange (Nasdaq Dubai) and an international commodities derivatives exchange (Gulf Mercantile Exchange). The DFSA is also responsible for supervising and enforcing anti-money laundering and countering the financing of terrorism requirements applicable in DIFC. Please refer to the [DFSA's website](#) for more information.

Charlotte Robins joined the DFSA in May 2024 as Managing Director of Policy and Legal. She is responsible for leading the further development of the DFSA's policy framework, managing legal risks, providing comprehensive legal advice and support across all DFSA functions, as well as drafting the administrative laws and rules that form the DFSA's regulatory framework. Prior to joining the DFSA, Ms Robins accumulated more than 22 years of experience as a private practice lawyer in Hong Kong. She advised a diverse range of financial institutions – including investment and private banks, fund and wealth managers, and insurance companies on financial services regulation - covering conduct and prudential requirements, strategic business development, regulatory change and risk management. Ms Robins began her career at Linklaters in London and Hong Kong, and joined Clifford Chance Hong Kong in 2002, and became a partner at Norton Rose Fulbright in 2011. In 2016, she joined at A&O Shearman (formally Allen & Overy) as a partner. Ms Robins is qualified to practice law in England and Wales, as well as in Hong Kong SAR.



Charlotte Robins, Managing Director, Policy & Legal, DFSA